

Accuse and blame

Teaching guide

Distinguish an allegation from an assignment of responsibility.

Understand the distinction

Accuse someone of something means say that the person did something wrong: accuse someone of lying. Blame someone for something assigns responsibility: blame the supplier for a delay.

An accusation is a claim, not proof. Use alleged, said, or according to when reporting an unestablished claim. In a practical discussion, describing an observed problem and asking for an explanation can be more useful than assigning blame.

Compare the patterns

ACCUSE OF

They accused him of sharing the file.

They claimed he did something wrong.

BLAME FOR

They blamed the delay on a missed delivery.

This assigns a cause.

OBSERVE

The file arrived after the deadline.

This states an observable event.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete: She accused him ___ copying.

A. to

B. for

C. of

2. Complete: They blamed me ___ the mistake.

A. for

B. of

C. at

3. Does was accused of prove that someone did it?

A. No. It proves the person did not do it.

B. No. It reports an allegation.

C. Yes. An accusation proves the action happened.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. You only know that the report arrived late. Which response gives that observation and asks for missing information?

- A. The report arrived after the deadline because you ignored it.
- B. You deliberately delayed the report. Why did you do that?
- C. The report arrived after the deadline. What caused the delay?

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. of

The pattern is accuse someone of something.

A: Accuse someone takes of before the alleged action.

B: The pattern is accuse someone of something. Blame someone for is a different pattern.

2. A. for

Use blame someone for something.

B: The pattern is blame someone for something; accuse someone of is different.

C: Use for to introduce the matter someone is blamed for.

3. B. No. It reports an allegation.

Keep the distinction between a claim and an established fact.

A: The accusation alone proves neither guilt nor innocence.

C: An accusation is an allegation, not proof.

4. C. The report arrived after the deadline. What caused the delay?

This states the observed fact and asks about the cause without assigning blame.

A: The stated facts do not establish that cause.

B: Deliberately assigns an intention that the facts do not establish.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-24.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

You only know that the report arrived late. Which response gives that observation and asks for missing information?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.